CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

GENERAL CONTRACTOR IN THE AI ERA

The conductor of the whole construction orchestra — no instrument required, but you'd better hear a wrong note from any section instantly.

★ **TL;DR — Median around $105K for established contractors — owners run far past it — on a 2–4 year experience road with state contractor licensing in most states. The catch: nobody starts here; this career is built out of a trade first, and the risk (money, liability, clients) is yours.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

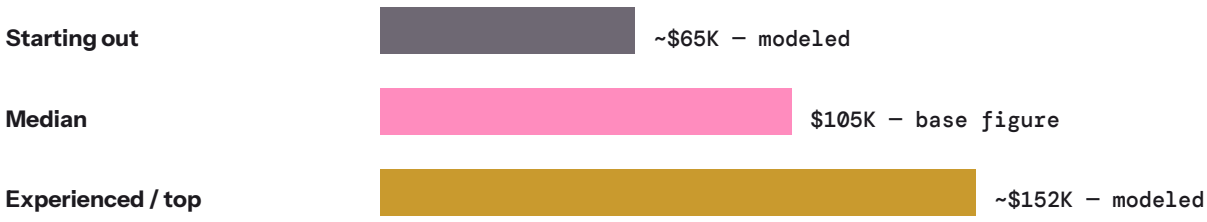
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$105K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Works because: every remodel and build needs one throat to choke and one brain coordinating trades, permits, money and schedule.
- Bites because: you carry the financial risk of everyone else's mistakes, delays and price swings.
- AI angle: minimal. Estimating and project software keeps improving; managing subs, inspectors, clients and chaos on physical sites is human work.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for General Contractor is a ~$105K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A GENERAL CONTRACTOR ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Estimate and bid jobs: measure, price materials and subcontractors, write contracts that protect everyone
- ✓ Sequence and supervise trades — demo, framing, electrical, plumbing, finishes — and inspect their work
- ✓ Handle permits, inspections, change orders and the client's emotions through all of it
- ✓ Run the money: draws, payroll, subs' invoices, and the margin that's decided by your paperwork discipline

Think: a film producer for buildings — you assemble the cast, the budget and the schedule, and the premiere is an inspector with a clipboard.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Takeoff and estimating software, scheduling apps, AI-assisted bids. The software has never once talked a framer back onto a job or found a client a sink that arrives Friday.	Judgment across every trade at once, negotiation, problem invention when the plan dies, and trust — clients hand GCs their homes and five-figure deposits.

⚠ **The failure mode is financial, not technical: underbid, under-document, or float one job's money into another, and a skilled builder goes broke with a full schedule. The trades part is the easy half of this career.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Variety at the highest level — different projects, problems and people constantly ✓ The money ceiling is genuinely yours to set ✓ You leave finished buildings and a name in a local market	✗ You carry the risk: callbacks, deadbeat clients, sub failures, price spikes ✗ Phone never off; every problem on every site is ultimately yours ✗ Cash-flow management is a weekly discipline, forever

Good fit? You have real trade years, business discipline and client calm; you price carefully, document everything, and return calls.
Bad fit? You want to start at the top without trade time, or you hate paperwork. Unlicensed dreamers underbid themselves into the cautionary tales.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — TRADE → FOREMAN → LICENSED GC	DOOR B — REMODELER / HANDYMAN BUSINESS, SCALED
The honest road: years in a trade (commonly carpentry or remodeling), up to lead/foreman running jobs, then your state's contractor license exam and your own company. The 2–4 year band assumes you arrive with hands-on years already — the license tests business and law as much as building.	Start with small jobs that don't require a GC license in your state, run them impeccably, and scale scope as you license up. Many successful GCs grew from remodeling crews one bathroom at a time — staying legal at each size is the discipline.

Smart move: Niche down to one profitable job type (kitchens, additions, insurance restoration) and one neighborhood tier. Specialist GCs price from reputation; generalist GCs price against desperation.

Where you land after: Foreman → licensed GC → established firm with crews and project managers; the company itself becomes the asset.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
BANK TRADE	LEARN ESTIMATING	PASS THE	BUILD THE	WIN A	SYSTEMATIZE AND

STEP 1 — Bank trade years first

PREREQUISITE · YEARS

- Work a core trade — carpentry/remodeling is the classic base — until you can judge every other trade's work.
- Run crews and small jobs as a lead: supervision reps are the GC apprenticeship.

STEP 2 — Learn estimating like a science

ONGOING

- Track real costs per job type until your bids are boring-accurate.
- Include the unsexy lines: permits, dump fees, warranty reserve, your own salary.

STEP 3 — Pass the contractor license exam

EXAM + STATE LICENSE

- Most states license GCs: business/law plus trade exams, financial and insurance requirements.
- Complete the license before taking licensed-scope work — the penalties for skipping this are career-sized.

STEP 4 — Build the business chassis

MONTHS

- Contracts with clear scope, payment schedules tied to milestones, and change-order discipline.
- Insurance, bonding capacity, an accountant who knows construction — set up before the big jobs, not after.

STEP 5 — Win a niche market

YEAR 1

- One job type, one area, done impeccably and photographed relentlessly.
- Referral partners — realtors, designers, past clients — beat advertising at this level.

STEP 6 — Systematize and delegate

YEAR 2+

- Project managers and trusted sub benches convert your hours into a company's capacity.
- Your job becomes estimating, relationships and quality — the parts only you can do.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: write down your trade years honestly and check your state's GC license requirements and experience prerequisites.

□ Days 1–30: start a real cost book from current jobs; identify your niche job type.

□ Days 31–60: license exam prep (business & law is where builders fail); contracts reviewed by a construction attorney.

□ Days 61–90: license application in motion; insurance and bonding quotes gathered; first niche jobs bid with your new numbers.

□ Day 90: the chassis is being built — license, paperwork, niche — on top of trade years that actually support it.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ THE BID IS THE JOB. PRICE IT LIKE ONE. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and

certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.